

Pre_Class_Thoughts_Open_Notebook_1

When I registered for this course, I didn't consider the mechanics of digital history, only the output. I immediately thought of online databases for archives/newspapers, interacting with digital programming in museums, and how lucky I am to live in an age where my historical research is done almost completely online. I didn't account for the production of these research materials for digital use. If I had, I pictured a scanner used to digitize century-old books, letters, and newspaper clippings. In hindsight, that does not seem effective for all that history has to offer. Admittedly, even as a graduate history student, I came into this course with a limited idea of what and where history is represented. After reading the syllabus, I can honestly say I was quite terrified. Coding is a word that should be in all caps and in bold, like a warning sign: "CODING: NOT FOR HISTORY STUDENTS."

With that being said, my dad has a background in coding, and so when I told him about this course, he asked me what language I would be coding in. To which I replied, "English." He then sent me a copy of "Python for Dummies: The Complete 7 Book Guide." With this in mind, I am quite nervous about how the semester will go. Will my classmates be experts? Will it be a computer science elective course? How will this apply to my MRE? But, as scared as I am, it seems like a fun way to learn a hands-on skill for post-grad life that my other two classes are not offering. To be able to go into a job and say I have (albeit limited) experience in Python or data management, for example, is something I couldn't say before.

As for its connection to Public History, I'm here at Carleton for this program to learn practical skills and eventually get a job. I'm very interested in how history can be engaged with by audiences that are not experts in history, or maybe claim to not like it at all. I am eager to see how the different tutorials can create something that draws in a new audience, or would be helpful in teaching history to a new audience. I also decided to take this course, as someone who isn't in digital humanities, to dip my toe in this world and learn something that traditional history classes don't typically teach. I think it should be interesting.

These are my hopes for this semester:

- I will gain some confidence in navigating the digital world.
- I will have a better understanding of the processes and difficulties it takes for historians to digitize their work.
- My final project will supplement my MRE in some way.
- I think of history in a new way.